Teaching Statement

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This statement describes my experience as a teaching assistant, the approach that experience has led me to, and the classroom I want to build from it. The appointments run from undergraduate courses at Sharif University of Technology, through master's courses there, to the Ph.D. sequence at the Institute for International Economic Studies. Across them I have come to one conclusion. Economics is taught best when the class is interactive. What changes with the level is the form of that interaction.

Teaching experience

In spring 2023 I assisted Dr. Mitman in Macroeconomics II, the Ph.D. course at the Stockholm University. It was the most engaging teaching I have done, and it felt refreshing. We worked back through the material by solving new problems, in a room of fellow Ph.D. students. A question from the class could raise a difficulty I had not come in with. Working through it added to my own knowledge of the models as well as to theirs.

During my master's I assisted in two graduate courses at Sharif, and they asked for a different kind of help. In spring 2019 I assisted Dr. Madanizadeh in Macroeconomics I. The course is heavy in mathematics and in coding, and its pace is regular: each week has a model to set up and a solution to reach. I focused on a step-by-step path, so that students could see the sequence rather than only the final expression. The sequence I kept returning to was how to pose a macroeconomic question, how to develop it with the mathematics of the course, and, when the question calls for it, how to solve it numerically.

In fall 2019 I assisted Dr. Nili in Iran's Economy. The course looks at the Iranian economy through macroeconomics and political economy at the same time. The aim was a wide view of a macroeconomic problem, with the line of thought kept to the steps the question required. I encouraged students to take the lead. When an assumption, a method, or a deduction went wrong, I corrected that step and handed the argument back to them.

At the undergraduate level the task was to convey a core idea in a course that was still extensive, in keeping with the usual standard at Sharif. In fall 2018 and spring 2018 I assisted Dr. Mahmoudzadeh in Introduction to Economic Growth and in Introduction to Money and Banking. Both courses work mainly through qualitative frameworks, and both cover a wide literature. My effort there was to make the central idea of each framework understandable on its own terms. In fall 2017 I assisted Dr. Bakhshiyani in Introduction to Macroeconomics, which introduces the basic concepts of macroeconomic models. I tried to put those concepts in place by working them out with the class.

How I want to teach

All of this teaching has been as an assistant. The practice I want to implement, when I am the one designing the course, is that same interaction, chosen to fit the level.

In an undergraduate course I want the class to think together about a basic concept, and I want students to raise questions about the mechanism, including questions that push against what they already believe. Growth, money and banking, and introductory macroeconomics are where that kind of question does the most work. The goal is that the core idea survives in the student's own words.

In a master's course I want students engaged with the details of the model: why a piece is there, and how the model is solved one step at a time. Macroeconomics I is the template for that path, from the question, through the mathematics, to a computation when one is needed. Iran's Economy adds a second discipline to the same habit. The view stays wide enough for the economy at hand, and the argument stays only as complicated as the question requires. Students hold the thread of the reasoning. I correct the assumption, the method, or the deduction, and they continue.

In a Ph.D. course I want the participants to take a share of the teaching. They set out their reading of a model, and I guide the discussion and challenge it. The depth I care about is specific. What is the paper doing, what could be done to improve it, and which technique from it is worth carrying away? Macroeconomics II showed me that this exchange teaches the assistant as well as the class. I want that to be a feature of the course.

I am prepared to teach undergraduate introduction to macroeconomics, intermediate macroeconomics, economic growth, and money and banking, and the graduate core in macroeconomics. I can also teach a course that joins macroeconomic reasoning with the political economy of a particular economy, and a methods or field course on quantitative macroeconomic models, including heterogeneous-agent models, drawn from my research.